

E9 Removing Outdated Processes

Pillar	Enablement	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	35-45 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	E1 or E5 often surface the processes that need removing	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Innovation blocked by legacy practices, outdated processes, frustration with bureaucracy, time wasted on unnecessary steps, resistance to change

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Outdated processes create a specific neurological drain: the brain expends cognitive resources following steps it recognises as unnecessary. This produces a unique frustration pattern where the prefrontal cortex (rational brain) knows the process is wasteful but the compliance circuits (social conformity) prevent deviation. The result is cognitive dissonance that sustains low-level cortisol.

Removing unnecessary process steps produces an immediate dopamine response: the brain registers the removal of friction as a reward. This is why process simplification often produces engagement gains that are disproportionate to the time saved. It is not just about efficiency. It is about the brain recognising that someone listened, something changed, and the work got easier.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Process Autopsy (15 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Every team accumulates processes over time. Some were created for good reasons that no longer exist. Some were someone's solution to a problem that's been solved another way. Some nobody can remember the origin of. Today we're going to find them and decide which ones can be eliminated, simplified, or kept."

Each person identifies 2-3 processes, approvals, reports, or meetings that they believe are unnecessary or could be simplified. Write each one on a sticky note with a one-line description of what it is and why they think it's outdated.

Phase 2: The Three Questions (15 minutes)

For each process identified, the team applies three questions:

6. Why was this created? (If nobody can answer this, it's a strong signal that it can go.)
7. What would happen if we stopped doing it tomorrow? (If the answer is 'nothing,' eliminate it. If the answer is 'we'd lose X,' assess whether X is worth the cost of the process.)
8. Could this be simplified rather than eliminated? (Sometimes the purpose is valid but the execution is bloated.)

Categorise each process: Eliminate / Simplify / Keep / Needs investigation (someone needs to check with another team or leadership before changing).

Phase 3: The Kill List (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Here's what we're going to do. The 'eliminate' items: I'll remove or stop requiring these by end of week. The 'simplify' items: I'll work with [relevant person] to redesign them. The 'investigate' items: I'll find out why they exist and report back. By our next team meeting, at least two of these will be gone."

Specificity and speed matter. If the manager says "we'll look into it" and nothing changes, the exercise teaches the team that surfacing problems is pointless.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A process exists because another department requires it	"That's worth investigating. I'll check whether they still need it, whether the format could be simplified, or whether there's a lighter way to give them what they need. Sometimes processes persist because nobody ever asked whether the downstream consumer still uses the output."
Someone is attached to a process because they created it	Frame it as evolution, not criticism: "Processes that were right 12 months ago may not be right today. That's not a reflection on the original design. It's just how work evolves. What mattered when you created it? Does that still apply?"
The team identifies a process that the manager instigated	Own it: "I started that because [reason]. If the reason no longer applies, let's kill it. I'd rather remove my own unnecessary process than defend it out of ego."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	- The team identifies processes that surprise even the manager - The three questions produce honest answers, not defensive justifications - The kill list has at least 2-3 actionable items
Within 2 weeks	At least one process has been eliminated or simplified

	Someone says "we don't do that anymore" and it feels like a relief Time previously spent on removed processes is visibly recaptured
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Enablement scores increase Frustration and bureaucracy signals decrease Qualitative data references simplification, efficiency, or removing barriers
Red flags	If the kill list exists but nothing actually changes, the exercise produced a list, not an action. The manager must follow through within days, not weeks.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
E1: Shared Struggles	E1 surfaces process barriers informally. E9 addresses them systematically.	E1 feeds into E9
E3: Delegation Audit	E3's 'nobody should do this' category feeds directly into E9.	E3 feeds into E9
C12: Information Fatigue	Communication processes (unnecessary reports, redundant meetings) are a common E9 target.	Complementary
C1: Communication Audit	Outdated communication channels identified in C1 may need E9's removal process.	Complementary